

Inside Flipkart's largest warehouse

Making sense of it all with Flipkart's **Bharath Chinamanthur**

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On the drive into Haringhata, a sleepy town outside Kolkata, you wouldn't expect to find one of India's most sophisticated logistical machines. Known more for poultry and fields than commerce, the place seems an unlikely setting for Flipkart's largest fulfillment centre – a 2-million-sq-ft structure like an airport terminal.

Getting inside is no small feat. Three layers of security checks stand between visitors and the humming heart of India's e-commerce. "Airport security is casual compared to this," one guard tells me, only half-joking. Inside, the logic is simple – inbound docks on one end, outbound bays on the other – but what happens in between is a ballet of conveyors, robots, scanners, and a workforce moving with near-military discipline.

"Every physical step... has a corresponding software, technology, AI, machine learning component to all of it," says Bharath Chinamanthur, Flipkart's SVP for fulfillment and supply chain technology. "So almost everything is orchestrated with a high degree of sophistication."

I watch as a shipment of smart-phones is logged, X-rayed, and sealed

with Flipkart's insignia – a ritual repeated thousands of times daily. "We are the platform. We are responsible for it all the way... once we pick it up from a seller, the chain of custody lies with us till it ends with the customer's hand," Bharath says.

From there, items enter the "blue tote highway," plastic bins coursing along spiral conveyors up to six mezzanine levels. The system remembers every product's size, thanks to laser-guided scanners that calculate the ideal packaging the first time an item enters the network. That precision feeds into Flipkart's sustainability push – minimizing packaging waste, installing solar panels on the roof, and quietly building green practices into the bones of the centre.

The scale is staggering. A nine-kilometre conveyor system snakes across the building, overseen from a glass-walled control room where screens flash red, yellow, green to show traffic flow. If one belt clogs, the system reroutes itself. "We have robotic pickers... one of the largest cross-belt sorters," Bharath says. "Over

time, we will continue to replicate this across India."

For all the machine choreography, the human element is unmistakable. Women work side-by-side with men in packaging and quality control, while automated vehicles ferry the heavy loads. "The most important is a human level," Bharath stresses. "It can't just be technology. A lot of unique innovations come from every FC."

The timing of my visit – just before Big Billion Days 2025 – revealed the pressure behind the polish.

Months of planning go into positioning inventory, advising sellers, and preparing for one crore daily delivery touchpoints. "All of this is done with one obsession: to delight the customer," Bharath says. That obsession

extends to Flipkart's newest frontier: Minutes, its 10-minute delivery experiment. "Customers are increasingly getting

used to faster deliveries – even for larger assortments that traditionally might take two or three days," Bharath explains. "Quick commerce has played an important role in shaping this expectation."

Yet the most revealing moment comes when Bharath drops his guard. "Sometimes it may not be the seller's fault... we could have picked the wrong item. So we can't just say the seller sent it... once it's with us, it's our responsibility." It's a rare admission in an industry that often points fingers elsewhere. But standing in Haringhata, with thousands of workers and terabytes of algorithms keeping promises alive, you sense why Flipkart calls itself, above all, a supply chain company. **d**



Bharath Chinamanthur
Flipkart's SVP for fulfillment and supply chain technology

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